various aspects of his life and times emerging with variations. The *Ashoka* of Devadatta Ramakrishna Bhandarkar, Carmichael Professor of Ancient Indian History and Culture in Calcutta University, appeared two decades after Smith's book and relied on Ashoka's epigraphs and monuments for a history of the ruler, who was described as 'the royal missionary'.[48] Much more space was devoted to the nature of Ashoka's engagement with Buddhism and the morality that he advocated over his paternalistic conception of kingship.[49] 'Ashoka's place in history'—a phrase much used by historians in the first half of the twentieth century—was the subject of a whole chapter, with Bhandarkar believing that Ashoka was second only to the Buddha in the history of the sect. The emperor's exuberance may by its excess have disturbed the balance between the material and the spiritual in ancient India, but Bhandarkar's recognition of this flaw did not allow him to upset the balance of his overall admiration. Radhakumud Mookerji's *Asoka* was in the same mould, with chapters on history, administration, and monuments.[50] The bulk of his volume was devoted to the texts—to translation and annotation of the inscriptions.

Of the early works on Ashoka there are good reasons for seeing Beni Madhab Barua's *Asoka and his Inscriptions* (1946) as diverging in many ways from the books by Smith and Barua's older Bengali contemporaries. Barua used a wider panorama of sources and strove to structure a different kind of account around Ashoka. His use of epigraphs was extensive, though he invariably attempted to also weave textual references into them. Importantly, and perhaps for the first time, the *Arthashastra* now came to be carefully mined for understanding the Mauryan state. Different facets of the same phenomenon were juxtaposed in the narrative: imperial and provincial administration, Ashoka's personal and public life, rajadharma and upasaka dharma in relation to its more universal Ashokan form. Barua's assessment of Ashoka's 'place in history' could, for all this, have been written by either Smith or Bhandarkar: 'Asoka did for the religion of Buddha what Darius